Abdulkhabir Isa Musa

Ustadz Abdulkhabir Isa Musa is a Filipino Islamic scholar, educator, and public servant who currently serves as a **Commissioner** of the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (NCMF), holding the seat dedicated to the **Ulama Sector**.

He's one of the more respected voices in Muslim Mindanao today, the kind of scholar whose work doesn't stay inside the mosque walls. Whether he's delivering a khutbah at the Sadik Grand Mosque in Zamboanga City, sitting with regional ulama on matters of community guidance, or now advising national policy from his seat at the NCMF, Ustadz Musa has always carried the same steady message: Islam in the Philippines is a faith of peace, moderation, and service.

His appointment by President Ferdinand R. Marcos Jr. in May 2026 brings a theological voice directly into national governance, ensuring that the perspectives of the country's religious scholars aren't just heard in prayer halls but in the halls of government as well.

Contents

1 Background
2 Education
3 Religious and Community Leadership
    3.1 Khateeb and Public Preacher
    3.2 Ulama Supreme Council of Zamboanga Peninsula
    3.3 Interfaith Advocacy and Dialogue
4 Appointment as NCMF Commissioner
5 Philosophical and Scholarly Contributions
    5.1 Unity (Wahdah)
    5.2 Moderation (Wasatiyyah)
    5.3 Madrasah Education Reform
6 Legacy
7 Recognition
8 See Also

Background

The specifics of Ustadz Musa's early life are kept private, as is common for many ulama who prefer their public legacy to speak through their work rather than personal biography.

What is well established is that his roots are in the Zamboanga Peninsula, a region that sits at the crossroads of multiple Muslim Filipino communities, from the Tausug and Yakan to Sama and Chavacano-speaking Muslims.

Growing up in that kind of diversity likely shaped the deeply pluralistic and unifying outlook that has come to define his scholarship and community work.

Education

Ustadz Musa received his formation in one of the most respected centers of traditional Islamic learning in the world: **Damascus, Syria**.

His studies there covered the three pillars that serious students of Islam pursue at that level: **Islamic Jurisprudence (Fiqh)**, **Theology (Aqidah)**, and **Arabic Linguistics**.

That combination isn't incidental. Fiqh gives a scholar the tools to apply Islamic law to real-life situations. Aqidah grounds the faith in sound theological principles. And fluency in classical Arabic makes it possible to work directly from the original sources, not just translations or commentaries.

Together, those disciplines produced a scholar who can engage both the tradition and the present moment with equal confidence.

Religious and Community Leadership

Khateeb and Public Preacher

Ustadz Musa has long been a regular presence on the pulpit, most prominently at the **Sadik Grand Mosque** in Zamboanga City.

His sermons aren't the fire-and-brimstone variety. He's known for drawing connections between classical Islamic texts and the real social challenges his community faces, touching on themes like family values, civic responsibility, and the importance of peace.

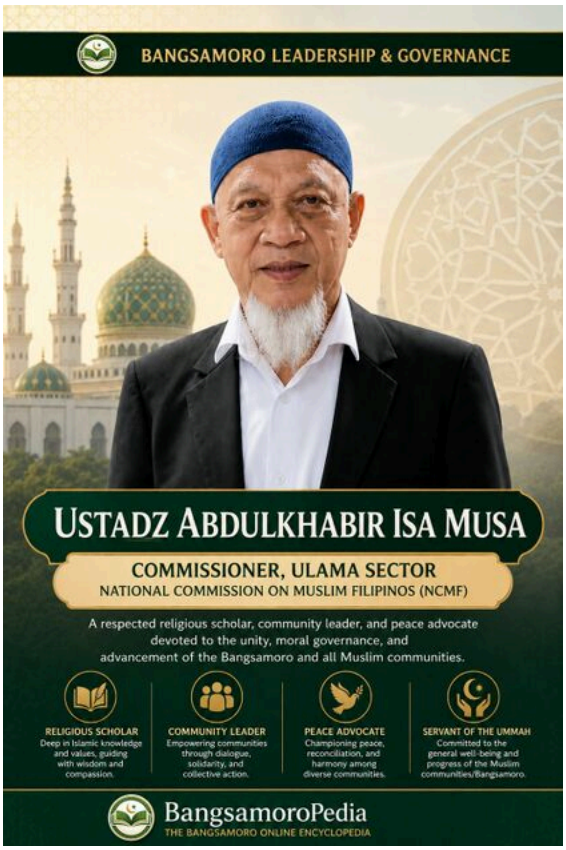
That ability to make the tradition feel alive and relevant, rather than distant and legalistic, is a big part of why he's become a trusted voice across different generations of Filipino Muslims.

Ulama Supreme Council of Zamboanga Peninsula

Beyond the pulpit, Ustadz Musa plays an active role in the **Ulama Supreme Council of the Zamboanga Peninsula**, one of the regional bodies that handles religious rulings and community guidance for the area's Muslim population.

That kind of institutional involvement means his influence extends well past individual congregations. Regional ulama councils shape how Islamic teaching gets applied across a wide range of social and legal questions, and being a contributing member of that body reflects a significant level of trust within the scholarly community.

Abdulkhabir Isa Musa



Title	Ustadz; Commissioner
Office	Commissioner, National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (Ulama Sector)
Appointed by	President Ferdinand R. Marcos Jr.
Date of Appointment	May 2026
Sworn in by	NCMF Secretary Sabuddin N. Abdurahim
Ethnicity	Tausug
Religion	Islam (Sunni)
Region	Zamboanga Peninsula; Bangsamoro
Known for	Islamic scholarship, community leadership, interfaith advocacy, Madrasah education reform

Interfaith Advocacy and Dialogue

Ustadz Musa has also been a consistent participant in interfaith symposia and dialogue initiatives, working across the religiously plural communities of Mindanao and Tawi-Tawi.

He's a proponent of **"Pagkasilasa"**, a concept that translates roughly as mutual love and affection among people of different backgrounds. That framing, drawn from local cultural vocabulary rather than imported terminology, reflects an approach that feels genuinely rooted in the communities he serves.

His interfaith work isn't performative. It's part of a coherent vision of what Muslim Filipino citizenship looks like: engaged, confident in its faith, and open to building bridges across difference.

Appointment as NCMF Commissioner

In May 2026, President **Ferdinand R. Marcos Jr.** appointed Ustadz Musa as Commissioner of the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos, assigning him to the **Ulama Sector** seat.

He was formally sworn into office by **NCMF Secretary Sabuddin N. Abdurahim**.

The NCMF is the primary government body tasked with promoting the welfare of Muslim Filipinos, coordinating Islamic cultural and religious affairs, and ensuring that state programs are responsive to the needs of the country's Muslim communities.

As Commissioner for the Ulama Sector, Ustadz Musa's specific mandate covers several areas:

- Advising the Commission on how Islamic principles can be integrated meaningfully into government programs.
- Representing the interests of religious educators, Islamic scholars, and Madrasah communities at the national level.
- Coordinating religious and cultural affairs, including the management and logistics of the annual **Hajj pilgrimage** for Filipino Muslims.

His appointment signals a recognition that theological expertise has a legitimate and necessary role in shaping how the Philippine government engages with its Muslim citizens.

Philosophical and Scholarly Contributions

Unity (Wahdah)

One of the central themes running through Ustadz Musa's work is the idea of **unity**, which he frames in the Islamic concept of *Wahdah*.

For him, the diversity of Muslim Filipino ethnolinguistic communities, Maranao, Tausug, Yakan, Sama, Maguindanao and others, isn't a source of fragmentation but a feature of the community's richness that needs to be managed with care and intentionality.

His advocacy consistently calls Muslim Filipinos to look past tribal and regional loyalties toward a shared identity grounded in faith and collective purpose.

Moderation (Wasatiyyah)

Ustadz Musa is firmly in the tradition of Islamic scholarship that champions *Wasatiyyah*, often translated as the **middle path** or moderation.

He rejects extremism in both its theological and political forms, and consistently advocates for an understanding of Islam that is compatible with peaceful coexistence within the Philippine state.

That isn't always an easy position to hold, especially in a region that has seen prolonged armed conflict. But his credibility as a trained scholar gives his moderation position genuine weight within the community.

Madrasah Education Reform

Ustadz Musa is a vocal champion of modernizing the **Madrasah education system** in the Philippines.

His argument is practical: Filipino Muslim students shouldn't have to choose between deep religious formation and the secular competencies they need to participate fully in society. A well-designed Madrasah curriculum can deliver both.

That advocacy connects directly to his role at the NCMF, where education policy and community development are central concerns.

Legacy

Ustadz Abdulkhabir Isa Musa represents a generation of Muslim Filipino scholars who've chosen engagement over withdrawal.

Rather than confining his learning to religious circles alone, he's taken his training from Damascus into mosques, council chambers, interfaith forums, and now a national government commission.

His legacy, still being written, is one of a scholar who understood that serving the community means meeting it where it is: in its complexity, its diversity, and its ongoing search for dignity and justice.

The appointment to the NCMF is, in many ways, a natural culmination of that long arc of service. He brings to public office what he's always brought to the pulpit: grounded knowledge, a genuine care for people, and a vision of Islam as a foundation for civic life, not a retreat from it.

Recognition

- Appointed by the President of the Philippines to the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (2026)
- Recognized member of the Ulama Supreme Council of the Zamboanga Peninsula
- Frequent resource speaker at major mosques and interfaith platforms across Mindanao and the Zamboanga Peninsula

See Also

- National Commission on Muslim Filipinos
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Madrasah Education in the Philippines

- Ulama in the Philippines
- Islam in the Philippines

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